



Brainstorming ideas: (L-R) Bhupinder Singh, former Punjab cricketer; Amarjit Singh Mehta, president, PCA; Gursharan Singh, former Punjab captain; Siddarth Kaul, Punjab and India cricketer, discuss ways to ameliorate state of Punjab cricket. R. V. MOORTHY

Beyond the boundary — Punjab cricket's tomorrow

After 30 years, Punjab lifted a domestic trophy in 2023, beating Baroda to win the Syed Mushtaq Ali T20 Trophy. However, the state has yet to taste success in red-ball cricket since its last win in the 1992-93 season.

"I don't think there is a mental block," said Siddarth Kaul, an India and Punjab cricketer, on Punjab's red-ball trophy drought. "It's more about the ability to change your game according to the format."

"Winning a trophy in white ball but missing out on red ball doesn't mean the players are not good," he added.

Gursharan Singh, the captain of the Punjab team that won the Ranji Trophy title in the 1992-93 season, highlighted the importance of the well-established cricket ecosystem in Punjab during the late 1980s.

"For the last 30-40 years, Punjab's [cricket] system -- the district and

inter-district matches -- has given exceptional results. For a hockey-playing state... winning the Ranji Trophy, a lot of credit must go to the players and the Punjab Cricket Association (PCA), as well as Bishan Paaji [Late Bishan Singh Bedi], our coach," he added.

"Four-day cricket is not entirely fading away but [is] having a backseat at the moment. We, as administrators of the game, have to do a lot to save it," Bhupinder Singh, a former Punjab cricketer, said.

"When I joined the PCA, the first question from the press was, 'When will the new stadium be completed?'. The next question was, 'When will Punjab's next trophy come?'" President of the PCA Amarjeet Singh Mehta revealed.

"We decided that a deadline must be fixed regarding the stadium. It is a matter of great pride for the PCA that Punjab's first game in the IPL, on March 23, will be held in the new Mullanpur stadium," he added.

